

Using AI in HAD 5744

Course policy on generative AI and coding assistants

The short version. You may — and should — use AI tools in this course, including generative chat assistants (ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini) and coding assistants (GitHub Copilot). I expect you to use them the way a working applied health systems researcher does: to move faster on the mechanical work, not to outsource your thinking. You remain fully accountable for everything you submit, including the parts an AI wrote. You also are expected to be able to provide in-depth explanations of everything you do and why you do it, as well as how you interpret your results. If you can't articulate what you did or why, you may have outsourced too much to AI.

Why this policy exists

The skills this course builds have split into two kinds. The first kind — writing the code to clean a dataset, build a summary table, run a regression, or make a figure — is now something AI does quickly and, usually, well. Fighting that is a waste of your time. The second kind — deciding *which* model answers the question, whether an identifying assumption holds, what a coefficient actually means, and whether a result is too good to be true — is exactly what AI cannot reliably do for you. It is also what makes you an applied researcher rather than a code monkey.

This course leans **into** AI for the first kind of work and deliberately raises the bar on the second. Assignments are built around that split.

What you are encouraged to do

- **Write and debug code with AI.** Use Copilot or a chat assistant to draft data-cleaning steps, regressions, tables, and figures. This is expected, not tolerated.
- **Learn with AI.** Ask it to explain an error message, a function, or a concept from lecture. It is an excellent, patient tutor. It's not a full substitute for office hours, but it does certainly help.
- **Draft with AI, then revise.** Use it to get a first pass on prose, then make it yours and make it correct.

What remains yours alone

The judgment parts of each assignment — motivation, DAGs, identifying assumptions, the choice of specification, interpretation for a decision-maker, and the error hunts — are meant to be reasoned through by you. You may use AI to check your thinking, but if you cannot reconstruct and defend an answer without it, you have not done the assignment. The video (★) component exists partly to keep this honest: it is hard to narrate reasoning you did not do.

Be warned: reading text that is obviously AI can give your instructor “the ick” and result in a worse grade!

The AI-use statement (required on every submission)

Every submitted assignment must end with a short AI-use statement — a paragraph covering:

1. **What tools you used** and roughly for what (e.g., “Copilot for the cleaning and plotting code; ChatGPT to explain a *feols* error”).
2. **How you checked the output.** How did you verify the code did what you intended and the results were sensible? What did you have to correct or redirect?
3. **Where you chose not to use it**, and why — typically the judgment and interpretation parts.

The “prompt + critique” artifact

On assignments that ask for it, you will submit, for one part, the actual **prompt** you gave the AI, the **raw output** it returned, and one or two sentences on where it went wrong or where you steered it. This is graded as evidence of skilled direction, not as a confession. Good reserachers are judged partly by the questions they ask; the same is true of prompts. Vague prompts that happened to work are weaker than precise prompts that caught a subtlety.

Where the lines are

- **Group work still means people.** AI does not replace your project group. Acknowledge your human collaborators as always.
- **You own the errors.** “The AI wrote it” is not a defense for an incorrect result, a fabricated citation, or a nonsensical interpretation. Treat AI output as a capable but unreliable co-author whose work you are signing.
- **Don't paste confidential or licensed data into external tools** unless you have cleared it. The course datasets are fine; be thoughtful with anything from your own research or workplace.
- **Omitting the AI-use statement** (or misrepresenting your use) is an academic-integrity issue, handled under the standard University of Toronto policies referenced in the syllabus.